

Sports **IPL**

CRISIS AFTER CRISIS

Tangles with the Government over its schedule, a TV contract in court and security concerns: the IPL Season 2 is in a race against time

| By Sharda Ugra |

From a self-proclaimed, recession-proof enterprise to a hairy logistical snafu and a scramble before *sarkar*, cricket's multimillion dollar T20 league has covered an awful lot of ground awfully fast. Within a month, the swaying palms of Goa have been replaced by North Block corridors and the rollout of Bollywood beauties and business moguls with the company of grim mandarins.

With less than three weeks to opening night, the Indian Premier League (IPL) has lurched from crisis to crisis, with every possible scenario—migration, compression, cancellation—being contemplated. The insouciant announcement of its dates before the Government had released the election schedule and boasts about 'hiring private security' have dissolved in the aftermath of the ambush of Sri Lankan cricketers in Lahore and a severe working over by the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Far from the IPL rhetoric of the six-week league being a reflection of national capability

THE IPL
had disallowed
political
advertising but
Commissioner
Modi (right)
denies this has
had any bearing
on how the
Centre and
states have
dealt with them



SUBIR HALDER

or even honour, BCCI President Shashank Manohar told INDIA TODAY, "That (the IPL) is not the most important thing in the country... Elections are more important than any cricketing event." It would seem a self-evident truth but it has taken a two-week tangle with the Government in Delhi to work that out. IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi denied that the League's image had been hurt or that there had ever been a tangle. "There is no question of it... We have been working with them, elections are important, so we had to work within the time frame and with all the logistics."

Removed from such surface smoothness, sources in the Home Ministry say that Home Minister P. Chidambaram refused to meet Modi despite repeated requests. Within the BCCI there is some mystery as to why the Home Ministry had been approached at all instead of going about the matter of permissions and police numbers in the conventional way—from the district administration upwards rather than a trickle down from Chidambaram's office. BCCI insiders say it was not Modi who went straight to the top but rather the Secretary N. Srinivasan,